

What Happens When AI Stops Advising and Starts Doing

If generative AI is the management consultant, agentic AI is the manager who rolls up its sleeves and gets the work done. But what will be its impact as people continue to adopt these advancements? This question framed a lively panel discussion in the session 'Autonomous Agents: What's Ready, Who's Ready, and Are You Ready?' at EFY's AI DevCon India, 2025.



(From L to R): Srivathsa NS, Unisys; Sunil Mishra, The Product Way; Sonia Taneja, Nutanix; Gaurav Gupta, Unisys, and Dr Devasia K., *astTECS

Prompt engineering was once considered the most coveted AI skill. Today, agents are creating their own prompts, highlighting the rapid evolution of AI. This transformation provides an opportunity to demystify autonomous agents and the technologies that power them.

Setting the context, Sunil Mishra, author and curator of The Product Way, a platform focused on digital product management, explains the concept through a simple analogy. “When compiling C code, I would get errors like ‘problem at line 13’ or ‘missing parenthesis’. I used to wonder, if the

compiler was so intelligent, why it could not fix the issue itself. That is where agent AI comes in. It sits between advising and acting.”

Mishra outlines a fundamental distinction between generative AI and agent AI. “Generative AI is like a management consultant. It offers advice but does not implement it. Agent AI not only advises but also acts on your behalf, doing the execution work. That is what makes it powerful.”

What sets agent AI apart is its ability to reason by iteratively editing, planning, and executing tasks to optimise outcomes. It can utilise

tools, connect to external systems, and operate in multi-agent environments, coordinating like a factory with specialists and managers handling escalation. Unlike generative AI, agent AI retains both short- and long-term memory, allowing it to optimise goals and continuously improve. “Combine these capabilities,” Mishra says, “and agent AI becomes a category of its own. 2025 represents a significant inflection point beyond ChatGPT.”

For organisations yet to adopt agents, what truly defines autonomy? Gaurav Gupta, Principal Engineer and AI specialist at Unisys, offers a